

The Dropout Autopsy

5 Questions That Reveal Why Your Learners Are Leaving

A DIAGNOSTIC WORKBOOK FOR COURSE CREATORS

WHAT THIS DIAGNOSTIC IS

Most course creators assume their learners are leaving because of the topic, the price, or the marketing. They're almost never right.

Learners leave because of design. And design problems have a fingerprint. This diagnostic gives you five questions that, together, reveal exactly where your course is structured to lose people.

Answer yes or no to each question. Read what your answer reveals. Write down what you notice in your own course. By the end, you will know which of the 8 Domains of Course Design needs the most attention.

1

Can you identify the exact lesson where your completion rate drops most sharply?

Domain 1: Engagement Architecture

YES

NO

IF YOU ANSWERED YES:

You have data. This is a good position to be in. The lesson where drop-off happens is almost never about the content, and it is almost always about the structure. Look at that lesson's hook, its pacing, and whether it gives the learner a reason to keep watching.

IF YOU ANSWERED NO:

You don't yet have visibility into where you're losing people. Before you change anything in your course, get this data. Most course platforms provide completion analytics at the lesson level. Without this, you are fixing the wrong things.

WHAT I NOTICED IN MY COURSE:

2

Does your course open with the learner's pain, not your credentials, or a welcome?

Domain 6: Course Structure and Hooks

YES

NO

IF YOU ANSWERED YES:

Your opening is learner-centric, which is the correct orientation. The first lesson is the moment when a buyer either becomes a learner or becomes a refund request. Starting with their pain keeps them.

IF YOU ANSWERED NO:

Your course likely opens with something like: "Welcome to this course, I'm so glad you're here." Or it starts with your background and credentials. Both of these signal to the learner that this course is about you, not them. The fix is simple: lead with a conflict the learner already feels.

WHAT I NOTICED IN MY COURSE:

3

Do your examples use named characters in specific situations, not abstract or hypothetical scenarios?

Domain 4: Storytelling and Abstraction

YES

NO

IF YOU ANSWERED YES:

Concrete named examples are one of the highest-leverage design decisions in course creation. The brain remembers stories and people, not principles and categories. You are working with how memory actually functions.

IF YOU ANSWERED NO:

Abstract examples are the single most common reason course content doesn't stick. If your examples use phrases like "imagine someone who" or "in many cases" or "typically," your learners are receiving information they cannot store. Replace your next abstract example with a named character in a specific situation and notice the difference.

4

Does every lesson begin with an identifiable hook in the first 30 seconds?

Domain 6: Course Structure and Hooks

YES

NO

IF YOU ANSWERED YES:

Lesson-level hooks are what turn a passive viewer into an active learner. If every lesson answers the question "why should I watch this right now" before the learner has a chance to ask it, your completion rates will reflect that.

IF YOU ANSWERED NO:

Most lessons in most courses begin with a recap, a title card, or a statement of what will be covered. None of these create forward momentum. A hook creates a question, a tension, or a stakes statement that can only be resolved by watching through to the end. Without it, every lesson is a potential exit point.

WHAT I NOTICED IN MY COURSE:

5

Can a learner who finishes your course tell someone else specifically what they can now do that they couldn't do before?

Domain 7: Learner Connection and Application

YES

NO

IF YOU ANSWERED YES:

A course with a clear, specific, transferable outcome is a course people recommend. Word of mouth in course creation is almost entirely driven by whether a learner can point to a specific transformation and say "I can do this now because of that course."

IF YOU ANSWERED NO:

Your course may be producing awareness rather than capability. This is more common than most creators realize. Ask yourself: if a learner finished your course and someone asked them what they can do now, would they answer with a verb (build, write, design, fix) or with a noun (knowledge, understanding, insight)? Verbs indicate real outcome. Nouns indicate information delivery.

WHAT I NOTICED IN MY COURSE:

YOUR DIAGNOSIS**How many NO answers?****out of 5****0 NO answers**

Strong diagnostic. Your course's structure is working in these five areas.

1 NO answer

One gap. Fix it in the order it appeared, since earlier gaps compound downstream.

2-3 NO answers

Meaningful structural issues. These are costing you completions. Prioritize the earliest NO.

4-5 NO answers

Foundational redesign is needed. Start with Question 1: visibility into your data, before anything else.